

THE STORIES THAT DON'T MAKE HEADLINES

Agriculture and farming in Sri Lanka, is more than just a livelihood. It is a tradition that has been passed down through generations. It is a legacy, that in recent history has slowly become a tale of hardship a cruel injustice. Farming and agriculture in the island have not failed because of a lack of incentive, drive or hard work – but because of factors that to the farmer seem far out his or her control. Unpredictable weather patterns, a lack of coordinated institutional planning and support, and global crises that have resulted in increased costs and unstable supply chains.

Small, everyday losses—the kind that rarely make headlines but slowly erode livelihoods. From a crop destroyed overnight, to water wasted before it reaches the soil, and hours lost carrying water buckets after a full day of labour. Over time, these small losses accumulate, locking families into cycles of vulnerability



This reality is especially visible in Nuwara Eliya, where estate communities face some of the highest levels of multidimensional vulnerability in the country. According to UNDP Sri Lanka's Understanding Multidimensional Vulnerabilities: Impact on People of Sri Lanka. A Policy Report Based on the Multidimensional Vulnerability Index, over 65 percent of estate-sector households experience overlapping deprivations, spanning income poverty, food insecurity, limited access to services, and exposure to climate and environmental risks. Women bear a disproportionate share of this burden. For estate-sector farmers, agriculture operates on extremely thin margins. Even a small loss can erase months of effort.



“We would grow vegetables with great difficulty, and just when we were ready to harvest, wild boar (swine) would come and destroy everything. When that happens, we cannot earn a living from farming.”
-Vaijyanthimala



“Watering our crops was a very difficult task. We used hoses or buckets with holes. Sometimes, by the time it was 6 in the evening and getting dark, we were still watering our crops. Four of us shared one well.” - Seetha

According to the World Bank's 2023 Poverty and Equity Report for South Asia, rural poverty in Sri Lanka has doubled between 2019 and 2023, and more than half of estate workers now live below the poverty line. As costs rise; especially energy and food, households are forced into coping strategies that further undermine long-term resilience.

In this context, agriculture is barely a livelihood and is a most fragile safety net — one that can be torn apart by the smallest external shock.

For many women farmers in the estate sector, irrigation itself is a daily struggle. Watering crops takes hours of hard physical labour.



In communities where women already work long, physically demanding hours under difficult estate conditions, wasted water and wasted time translate directly into lower productivity, lower incomes, and deeper vulnerability — a cycle where time poverty, environmental exposure, and economic insecurity reinforce one another.

With support from UNDP, funded by the Japanese Supplementary Budget of the Government of Japan, through the 'Empowering Women Smallholders Farmers through Renewable Energy-Based Agriculture Modernization Technologies' project, farmers at Hope Estate received sprinkler irrigation systems and protective fencing—deliberately designed to address the smallest but most damaging risks.



“When we used hoses, a lot of water was wasted, and when we used buckets, we wasted time instead.” - Kavipriya



**“Because we received a sprinkler irrigation system through the project, we are saving a lot of water and a lot of time. We can water the entire cultivation area at once.”
-Vaijayanthimala**



“Protective fencing was installed around our fields. Now, damage from wild animals does not happen. We can farm freely.”

These interventions were designed to reduce the everyday workload and stress of women farmers in the estate sector. They now have the time and energy to focus on the plethora of tasks including household care and wage work they are also responsible for.

“Compared to earlier, we are now cultivating a larger area. That is because water and time are saved. Now we farm with such happiness.”

In a sector where 62 percent of households rely on coping strategies just to access food, and where energy and climate shocks have previously triggered widespread social instability, these gains matter far beyond individual plots.

By addressing everyday risks rather than only large-scale crises, the intervention strengthens human security at its roots: protecting livelihoods, stabilizing incomes, and reducing the multidimensional vulnerabilities that keep estate communities trapped in poverty.

